account of Akbar's life, but a political, theological, even mythological basis for the emperor's existence and rule.

The research involved was tremendous. It was only in November of 1595, many years after Akbar had commissioned the work, that Abul Fazl sat down to write. 'A great joy seized me,' he says of those days. 'My heart renewed its vigour, and my useless pen drew a wondrous sketch.' Writers will know how rare this feeling is, and how wonderful, and may not be surprised that by April of the following year, in barely six months, Abul Fazl, thus absorbed, had written the first thirty years of Akbar's life.[1]

Abul Fazl was invited to present his work in court. 'Assemblies were convened for praise and censure of my labour, and cries of "bravo" and "boo" rang out.' His enemies and competitors 'sat gnashing their teeth in envy'.[2]

One of them may well have been Badauni who, not content with merely scowling at Abul Fazl's nonsense, decided to write his own version of events. In the opening pages of his secret history, Badauni states he will write an account of 'these 40 years from the accession of Akbar',[3] implying that he began to write in 1596, the very year that Abul Fazl presented his manuscript.

No sooner, that is, had one man written a story of Akbar than another began to compose a counter to it.

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Badauni was quite clear about his reasons for writing his rejoinder: 'my inducement to write this has been nothing but sorrow for the faith, and heart-burning for the deceased Religion of Islam'. Akbar's alleged abandonment of Islam and his Muslim subjects is, indeed, a recurring and bitter theme in some reports of Akbar's rule. A prominent Islamic theologian of the time, Shaikh Ahmad Sirhindi, wrote of how 'The infidels are demolishing mosques and building their own places of worship in their stead'. Among these was a mosque and a dargah by the lake of Kurukshetra, where Akbar had once watched ascetics at war. 'Both have been destroyed by the infidels and in their place they now have a big temple.'

That was not the end of it; if Shaikh Ahmad is to be believed, it wasn't only Muslim shrines but Muslim ways of life that were being taken over by